Less Is More: Why Exception Events Outperform Complete Traces for Verdict Prediction

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Abstract

Code language models increasingly incorporate execution traces, yet more trace information does not guarantee better performance. We present the first systematic component ablation of trace representations for verdict prediction—classifying whether a test passes or fails—across four models spanning three architecture families and a 1.5B–13B parameter range. Exception events alone achieve ≥99.33% accuracy on three of four models, while complete traces reach only ∼80% despite containing strictly more information. Training dynamics reveal why: `exception_only` converges within 50 training steps, whereas even `full_trace` with label-only loss (gradient dilution eliminated) oscillates throughout training without reaching stable accuracy—overfitting to spurious patterns in verbose content rather than learning the verdict signal. Decomposition analysis on Qwen-7B attributes the gap to information overload and gradient dilution from low-density tokens, and a tail-truncation budget sweep confirms a sharp phase transition between compact and verbose inputs. These results demonstrate that for trace-based verdict prediction, information density determines learning efficiency far more than information quantity.

1 Introduction

Execution traces (line-by-line records of a program's runtime behavior) have emerged as a promising input modality for code language models (Chen et al., 2025; Ding et al., 2024; Wang et al., 2025a; Ni et al., 2024). Yet feeding thousands of trace lines to a model can be no better than feeding none: the diagnostic signal drowns in routine execution steps. *Which trace components actually carry the signal that matters?*

Prior work found no single trace representation consistently outperforms others (Wang et al., 2025a), but focused on generation-oriented tasks. *Verdict prediction*—classifying whether a test passes or fails—offers a cleaner testbed: as binary classification, it isolates the learning signal from generation noise, enabling controlled component ablation. As fault detection, the model need not simulate execution, only determine whether something went wrong—and if that signal is concentrated in a small trace subset, information density should matter more than quantity.

We test this hypothesis through the first systematic component ablation of trace representations for verdict prediction. Using 591 problems from HumanEval (Chen et al., 2021) and MBPP-sanitized (Austin et al., 2021), we decompose a multi-component trace representation (VOTA: exception events + assertion-point comparisons + loop compression) into individual components across four models spanning 1.5B to 13B parameters and three architecture families: Qwen-2.5-Coder-7B/1.5B-Instruct (Team, 2024), CodeLlama-13B-Instruct (Rozière et al., 2024), and DeepSeek-Coder-6.7B-Instruct (Guo et al., 2024). The results are striking: complete traces (∼80%) underperform a single compact component (≥99%) despite containing strictly more information—a direct demonstration that information density, not quantity, determines learning efficiency.

Exception events alone achieve ≥99.83% verdict accuracy on three of four models (≥99.33% on 2/3 DeepSeek seeds; CodeLlama-13B seed 123 reaches 100%). DeepSeek-6.7B is the exception: its 3-seed mean is 96.58% (±4.76pp) due to one seed exhibiting format collapse (fail recall = 70.5%), though even this outlier outperforms VOTA (84.45%) by 6.64pp. This near-perfect accuracy holds from 1.5B to 13B parameters, while the code-only baseline (`no_trace`) varies from 67.3% to 76.5% with strong scale dependence. Train-

ing dynamics expose the mechanism (Figure 3): `exception_only` converges to 99.33% within 50 training steps and saturates at 99.83% by step 150, while even `full_trace` with label-only loss (gradient dilution eliminated) oscillates between 82% and 89% across the entire training without stable convergence, consistent with overfitting to spurious patterns in verbose content.

Adding trace information beyond exceptions provides no benefit and can degrade performance: VOTA (3-seed mean 99.05%) underperforms `exception_only` (99.83%) on Qwen-7B, with the gap reaching 14.96pp on DeepSeek due to tokenizer-driven truncation. The performance gap approximately decomposes into information overload (∼76%) and gradient dilution (∼24%) on Qwen-7B (3 seeds). A tail-truncation budget sweep across four models reveals a phase transition at ∼500 tokens, with `tail_2048` recovering 95–98% of `exception_only`'s accuracy. Even on silent logic errors (55.5% of failures), `exception_only` maintains 100% recall because test assertions generate exception events.

Our contributions:

1. **Information density determines SFT learning efficiency**: training dynamics directly show that denser trace components learn faster and more stably—`exception_only` converges within 50 steps while `full_trace` with label-only loss oscillates (82–89%) without stable convergence. Seed variance negatively correlates with input density (σ=0.00 to 1.12), and SFT closes a 6–49pp zero-shot gap across all models (§3.2, Appendix N).

2. **Exception events are the minimal sufficient signal**: ≥99.83% on three of four models, ≥99.33% on 2/3 DeepSeek seeds (1.5B–13B, three families), with ∼91% semantic rather than format-driven (§3.1, §3.3). Cross-dataset evaluation on DebugBench (N=426) preserves the ranking, though margins narrow from ceiling effects (§3.5).

3. **Approximate density decomposition (Qwen-7B, 3 seeds)**: The performance gap decomposes into gradient dilution (∼24%) and information overload (∼76%), implying content selection matters more than loss engineering. A budget sweep across four models reveals a phase transition at ∼500 tail tokens (§3.4, §3.5).

4. **Two-tier diagnostic hierarchy**: Tier 1 signals (exceptions, assertions) generalize across three models (≥99%), while Tier 2 (loop compression) is model-dependent: Qwen +10.9pp, DeepSeek +7.9pp, CodeLlama +0.6pp over no trace (§3.2).

2 Method

2.1 Task Definition

We study *verdict prediction*: given a Python function, a test input, and an optional execution trace, predict whether the test passes or fails. The model produces a single token (`pass` or `fail`), making this a binary classification task. Unlike code generation (Chen et al., 2025) or output prediction (Gu et al., 2024), verdict prediction isolates the model's ability to detect faults from its ability to simulate execution. The discrete binary outcome makes the effect of each trace component directly measurable, providing cleaner ablation contrasts than generation tasks where output quality varies continuously.

2.2 Dataset

We sampled 10 candidate solutions per problem from Qwen-2.5-Coder-7B-Instruct (temperature 0.8, top_p 0.95) for 591 problems from HumanEval (Chen et al., 2021) (164) and MBPP-sanitized (Austin et al., 2021) (427), executed each against canonical tests with `sys.settrace` to obtain line-level traces and pass/fail verdicts, yielding 5,910 pairs (67% pass, 33% fail). The dataset is split 80/20 by problem ID into 4,720 training and 1,190 test samples (majority baseline: 71.51%). The `exception_only` format collapses passing solutions into identical rows (39.45% train, 48.99% test duplicates); these duplicates arise from multiple candidate solutions per problem, with the train–test split enforced at the problem level (472 train / 119 test problems, zero crossover; Appendix O).

2.3 Trace Representations

We define seven conditions that vary the trace information available (Figure 1):

- `no_trace`: Source code and test input only.
- `full_trace`: Complete line-by-line trace with variable states.

- `VOTA`: Exception events + assertion-point comparisons + loop compression (Appendix C).
- `exception_only`: Only exception/error events.
- `ae_only`: Only assertion-point actual/expected pairs.
- `loop_only`: Only loop compression summaries.
- `VOTA_no_ae`: VOTA without assertion-point information.

2.4 Models and Training

We evaluate four models spanning three architecture families: **Qwen-2.5-Coder-7B/1.5B-Instruct** (Team, 2024), **CodeLlama-13B-Instruct** (Rozière et al., 2024), and **DeepSeek-Coder-6.7B-Instruct** (Guo et al., 2024), covering a 1.5B–13B parameter range (8.7×). All conditions use LoRA (Hu et al., 2022) (rank=16, α=32, dropout=0.05) on all linear layers, 3 epochs, effective batch size 32, LR 2×10^{-4} with linear warmup/decay, max sequence length 2,048 tokens. Sequences exceeding this limit are truncated while preserving the verdict label. The primary seed is 42; seeds 123 and 456 test `exception_only` robustness (Appendix B).

2.5 Loss Ablation

To disentangle training signal from input signal quality, we introduce `full_trace_label_only`: identical full-trace input but loss computed only on the verdict token (trace positions masked). Improvement over standard `full_trace` is attributable to *gradient dilution*; the remaining gap to VOTA reflects *information overload* at inference time.

3 Experiments

We evaluate across two research questions: (1) Do Tier 1 exception signals generalize across models? (2) What is the relative contribution of each trace component? All experiments use N=1,190 test samples; accuracy is reported with Wilson 95% CIs.[1] Pairwise comparisons use paired bootstrap resampling (B=10,000, seed=42); all differences are significant at $p<0.0001$ unless noted.

[1]Data is partitioned at the problem level (472 train / 119 test problems, zero crossover; §2.2). The `exception_only` format collapses passing solutions into identical rows (48.99% test duplicates; Appendix O), but these arise from within-problem variants, not cross-set leakage; deduplication sensitivity analysis confirms 0.00pp delta across all 19 experimental conditions.

Table 1: Cross-model verdict accuracy (%, N=1,190) across four models (1.5B–13B) and three architecture families. Multi-seed entries report mean±std over 3 seeds. Bold: best per model. Full per-seed breakdowns in Appendix E; per-class metrics in Appendix A.

Condition	Qwen-7B	Qwen-1.5B	CL-13B	DS-6.7B
exception_only	**99.83**±0.00	**99.83**±0.00	**99.89**±0.10	**99.33**[†]
ae_only	99.64±0.49	—	—	—
VOTA	99.05±0.38	99.58	98.57	84.45
loop_only	86.05±0.52	—	77.06	81.26
no_trace	75.13	67.31	76.47	73.36
Majority baseline		71.51		

[†]DeepSeek 3-seed mean 96.58%±4.76pp; seed 123 (91.09%, fail recall = 70.5%) exhibits format collapse on long inputs (Appendix N), reported as 2-seed mean excluding the outlier. VOTA on Qwen-7B: 99.41/98.66/99.08 (σ=0.38). `ae_only` 3 seeds: 99.92/99.08/99.92 (mean 99.64%); Qwen-7B `loop_only` 3 seeds: 85.63/85.88/86.64 (mean 86.05%). Qwen-1.5B `exception_only`: 99.83% across 3 seeds (σ=0).

3.1 Cross-Model Comparison

Table 1 compares four models spanning an 8.7× parameter range (1.5B–13B) and three architecture families (Qwen, DeepSeek, CodeLlama) under key conditions.

Exception dominance across families. Under `exception_only`, the Qwen and CodeLlama families achieve ≥99.83% (mean): Qwen-7B (99.83%±0.00, 3 seeds), Qwen-1.5B (99.83%), and CodeLlama-13B (99.89%±0.10, 3 seeds; seed 123 achieves 100%). DeepSeek-6.7B reaches 99.33% on 2/3 seeds with one LoRA-sensitivity outlier at 91.09% (seed 123; fail recall = 70.5%); even the outlier outperforms VOTA (84.45%) by 6.64pp. Excluding the DeepSeek outlier, the cross-model range is 0.56pp (99.33–99.89%), the tightest of any condition.

Scale invariance of exception signals. Exception-based accuracy is shared by models spanning 1.5B to 13B parameters (8.7×): both Qwen-1.5B and CodeLlama-13B achieve 99.83%+ on the same representation. CodeLlama-13B seed 123 achieves 100% (0/1190 errors), confirming that Qwen's two persistent errors (from `GeneratorExit`; Appendix G) are high-probability convergence artifacts rather than hard data limitations. In contrast, `no_trace` scales monotonically with capacity: 67.31% (1.5B) → 75.13% (7B) → 76.47% (13B), a

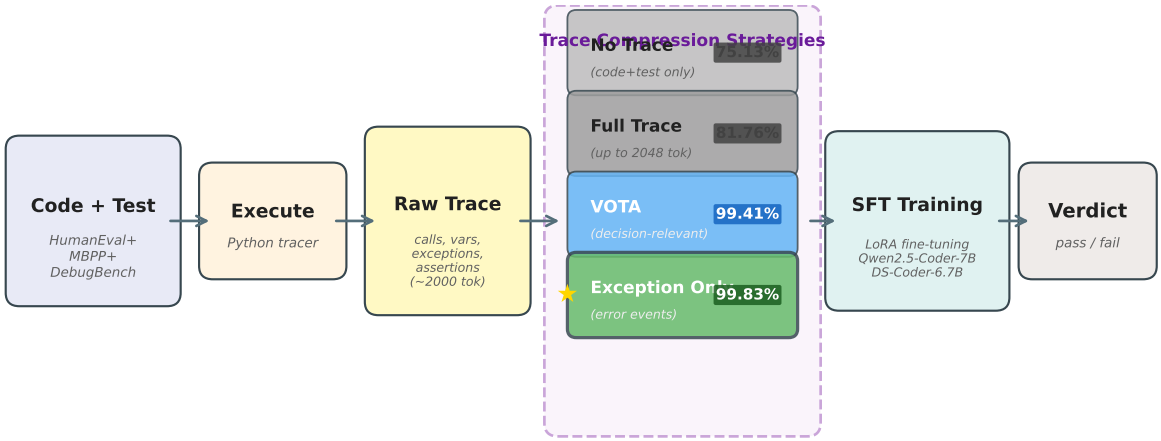


Figure 1: Overview of the verdict prediction pipeline. Source code and a test input are executed to produce a full raw trace. Four conditions vary the trace information: `no_trace` (75.13%), `full_trace` (81.76%), VOTA (99.41%), and `exception_only` (99.83%). Accuracies for Qwen-2.5-7B (seed=42, N=1,190). Appendix D provides input/output examples.

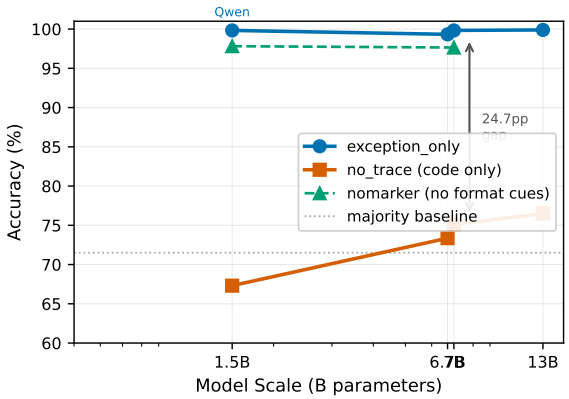


Figure 2: Verdict accuracy vs. model scale. `exception_only` maintains ≥99.33% regardless of scale (1.5B–13B), while `no_trace` shows monotonic scale sensitivity (+9.16pp from 1.5B to 13B). The `nomarker` condition (format markers removed) shows no degradation at smaller scale (∼97.7–97.8%).

9.16pp range that exception events completely eliminate (Figure 2).

VOTA cross-family variation. VOTA accuracy varies across families: 99.58% (Qwen-1.5B) > 99.05%±0.38 (Qwen-7B, 3 seeds) > 98.57% (CodeLlama-13B; CI [97.9, 99.2]) ≫ 84.45% (DeepSeek-6.7B). The CodeLlama result (17 errors) narrows the gap: among models without tokenizer-driven truncation, the VOTA range is only 1.01pp (98.57–99.58%), suggesting that the 14.96pp DeepSeek deficit is primarily a truncation artifact rather than an inherent model capability limitation (91.7% of DeepSeek training samples were affected; Appendix F). In contrast, `exception_only` inputs are compact (median 150 tokens, mean 398 due to verbose fail-class exceptions), making the cross-model comparison clean (Appendix M).

3.2 Component Ablation

We restrict `ae_only` ablations to Qwen-7B; `loop_only` is evaluated across three models to test Tier 2 generalization (Table 1). Table 2 decomposes VOTA on Qwen-2.5-7B and reveals a two-tier hierarchy: Tier 1 (`exception_only`) generalizes across all four models (≥99.33%), while Tier 2 (`loop_only`) is model-dependent.

Tier 1 signals are individually sufficient: `exception_only` (99.83%±0.00) exceeds VOTA (99.05%±0.38) by +0.78pp (2/3 seeds $p<0.05$, all directionally consistent), implying that combining signals introduces noise. Removing assertion points has no effect (`VOTA_no_ae` = 99.41%, single seed), confirming exception dominance. Tier 2 `loop_only` lifts over `no_trace` are model-dependent: Qwen-7B +10.92pp (86.05%, $p<0.0001$), DeepSeek +7.90pp (81.26%, CI [79.08, 83.45]), CodeLlama +0.59pp (77.06%, n.s.).

Rule-based baseline comparison. The strongest non-trivial regex heuristic (B4: exception class name matching; Table 19) achieves 93.61% accuracy (F1=0.876), trailing SFT `exception_only` (99.83%, F1=0.997) by

Table 2: Component ablation on Qwen-2.5-7B (N=1,190). Tier 1 signals achieve near-perfect accuracy; combining them (VOTA) slightly dilutes performance. [†]`ae_only`: 3-seed mean 99.64%±0.49 (seeds 42/123/456: 99.92/99.08/99.92). `exception_only`: 99.83%±0.00 (3 seeds). [§]VOTA: 3-seed mean 99.05%±0.38 (99.41/98.66/99.08). [‡]`loop_only`: 3-seed mean 86.05%±0.52 (85.63/85.88/86.64). Seed variance negatively correlates with information density: σ=0.00 (exception) < 0.38 (VOTA) < 0.49 (ae) < 0.52 (loop).

Condition	Components	Acc (%)	95% CI	Tier
ae_only	assertion-point	99.64[†]	[99.26, 99.87]	1
exception_only	exception events	**99.83**	[99.58, 100.00]	1
VOTA	exc+ae+loop	99.05[§]	[98.49, 99.50]	—
VOTA_no_ae	exc+loop	99.41	[98.90, 99.80]	—
loop_only	loop compression	86.05[‡]	[83.97, 87.96]	2
full_trace	complete trace	81.76	[79.70, 83.90]	—
no_trace	none	75.13	[72.77, 77.48]	—
Regex (best)	exc. type regex	93.61	—	—
3-shot (Qwen-7B)	in-context learning	90.84	—	—
Zero-shot (4 models)	prompting	51.0–93.5	—	—

6.22pp (McNemar p<0.001). The gap concentrates on caught-exception boundary cases: regex flags all exception events as failures, while SFT learns to distinguish caught exceptions (benign, inside `try/except`) from uncaught faults, correctly resolving 6/8 boundary samples (Appendix P). Across trace formats, SFT consistently outperforms the best applicable regex, from +3.62pp (`no_trace` over majority baseline) to +23.86pp (VOTA), with the largest gains on formats requiring semantic interpretation (Appendix P).

Zero-shot and few-shot LLM baselines. Zero-shot prompting spans 51.0–93.5% across four models (42.44pp range), with performance uncorrelated with model size (Qwen-1.5B: 93.45% vs. CodeLlama-13B: 51.01%). Three-shot ICL on Qwen-7B (90.84%) improves only 1.76pp and still trails SFT by 8.99pp. SFT compresses this 42.44pp range to 0.56pp (99.33–99.89%), closing a 6–49pp gap with 4,720 training samples (Appendix Q).

3.3 Format Marker Ablation

The `exception_only` format includes a `[No exception data in trace]` marker in all pass-class samples (regex baseline B5 exploits this for 99.33% accuracy; Appendix P). To quantify the marker's contribution, we retrain with all format markers removed (`nomarker` condition).

Qwen-7B 3-seed mean: 97.65% ± 0.96 (seeds 42/123/456: 96.55/98.32/98.07%), a drop of 2.18pp from `exception_only` (99.83%). Qwen-1.5B: 97.82%, drop of 2.01pp. The marker contribution (∼2pp) accounts for only ∼9% of the total exception lift over `no_trace` (24.70pp on 7B). Exception events thus provide two signal layers that show no degradation at smaller scale: structural markers (∼2pp, regex-learnable) and semantic exception content (∼22pp, requiring SFT to distinguish caught from uncaught exceptions).

Table 3: Approximate information density decomposition: gradient dilution (∼24%) vs. information overload (∼76%). `label_only` and VOTA are 3-seed means on Qwen-7B.

Condition	Acc (%)	Δ vs. full_trace	Gap explained
full_trace	81.76	—	—
label_only	85.94±1.12	+4.18pp	24%
VOTA	99.05±0.38	+17.29pp	100%

3.4 Information Density Decomposition

The 17.29pp gap between `full_trace` (81.76%) and VOTA (99.05%, 3-seed mean) decomposes via `full_trace_label_only` (85.94%±1.12, 3 seeds; Table 3), which retains the full trace but masks all trace tokens from the loss.

Gradient dilution accounts for approximately 24% of the gap (+4.18pp, 3-seed mean): when the model no longer wastes gradient updates on predicting trace tokens, accuracy improves even with identical input. The remaining ∼76% (+13.11pp) reflects information overload at inference: the model receives thousands of irrelevant trace lines that compete for attention with the diagnostic signal, regardless of loss design. This asymmetry implies that trace compression methods should prioritize *content selection* (removing irrelevant lines) over *loss engineering* (masking non-target tokens), as the larger bottleneck is what the model sees, not how it is trained. The two factors may interact, so this decomposition is approximate. Label-only loss simultaneously changes multiple optimization dynamics (effective gradient norm, implicit regularization from trace token prediction); the 24%/76% attribution should be interpreted as an approximate decomposition rather than a strict causal partition. This analysis uses 3 seeds on a single model (Qwen-7B); cross-model validation remains future work.

3.5 Additional Analyses

Trace length ablation. Varying the head-truncated trace token budget (256–no limit) on Qwen-7B yields accuracy in a narrow 77.2%–81.8% band with a non-monotonic pattern: 1024-token prefixes (77.23%) underperform 512-token prefixes (80.42%, p=0.002), because mid-length prefixes retain enough irrelevant content to mislead the model while discarding diagnostic events near the trace terminus (Appendix I). This non-monotonicity is specific to head-truncation; under tail-truncation, accuracy increases monotonically for two of three models (Table 12 in Appendix), with only DeepSeek showing a mild architecture-specific reversal at tail-1024→tail-2048 (−1.5pp).

Truncation direction and budget curve. Tail-truncation (retaining the last k tokens) dramatically outperforms head-truncation: among the three models with complete data, tail-2048 exceeds head-2048 by 15.5–22.6pp, with the gap widening at smaller scale (Qwen-1.5B: +22.6pp vs. Qwen-7B: +15.5pp; Appendix I, Table 13). All four models' head-2048 accuracies converge into a narrow 75.3–81.8% band (6.5pp), comparable to the tail-256 band (72.6–78.9%, 6.3pp), indicating that signal-poor conditions produce a shared performance floor regardless of scale or architecture.

A cross-model budget sweep across four models and three architecture families reveals a phase transition localized between 384 and 512 tail tokens. At tail-384, all models remain near baseline (73.6–82.9%, only +1.0–6.5pp over tail-256); the steep jump occurs at 384→512 (+11.0–22.0pp), crossing from near-baseline to near-ceiling (∼94–98%). This localizes the critical threshold to ∼400–500 tokens, matching the typical exception traceback length (Table 12). Beyond 512 tokens, accuracy converges further: multi-seed validation across all 12 model×seed combinations confirms all tail-512 accuracies fall within a 4.63pp band [93.61%, 98.24%] (Table 14); at tail-1024, three models reach 96.5–98.2%, compressing the 6.3pp cross-model spread observed at tail-256. `tail_2048` captures 95–98% of `exception_only`'s accuracy across all completed configurations. The residual 2–5pp gap confirms that semantic extraction (identifying exception type and message) still outperforms positional extraction (retaining a fixed window containing non-diagnostic lines).

Calibration. Calibration mirrors the tier hierarchy: `exception_only` achieves ECE = 0.0027 vs. 0.171 for `no_trace`, a 63× gap (Figure 5). This calibration advantage generalizes across models: all three tested architectures achieve ECE < 0.007 under `exception_only` (Appendix J).

Error orthogonality. `exception_only`'s 2 errors have zero overlap with all other conditions' error sets (Jaccard = 0.000), confirming it operates on an independent signal dimension (Appendix K).

Exception type breakdown. A per-exception-type breakdown (Appendix H) confirms that all standard exception types achieve 100% accuracy; the only failures arise from `GeneratorExit`, a benign `BaseException` subclass.

Cross-dataset generalization. On DebugBench (Tian et al., 2024) (N=426), the ranking is preserved: `exception_only` 100%, VOTA 99.77%, `no_trace` 96.71%; narrow margins reflect a ceiling effect from structurally distinctive mutations (Appendix L).

4 Discussion

The central finding is that information density determines learning efficiency for trace-based verdict prediction. Exception events concentrate the runtime's primary fault signal—error type, stack frame, and message—in a compact format (median 150 tokens), while non-exception components (variable states, loop iterations, control flow) record *how* the program ran, not *whether* it failed.

This density perspective explains three key results: (1) adding trace information beyond exceptions provides no benefit (VOTA < `exception_only`, Table 2), because low-density content competes for attention; (2) a budget sweep reveals a phase transition at 384→512 tail tokens (+11.0–22.0pp), matching the boundary where diagnostic events dominate, with `tail_2048` capturing 95–98% of `exception_only`; (3) the 6.22pp SFT advantage over regex concentrates on caught-exception boundary cases, confirming semantic signal extraction. The 0.56pp cross-model gap supports that signal density, not model capacity, is the binding constraint.

Why exception_only outperforms ae_only. Although `ae_only` is a strict superset, multi-seed evaluation reveals that extra content introduces noise: `ae_only` achieves 99.64%±0.49 while `exception_only` achieves 99.83%±0.00, indicating that `exception_only` captures a minimal sufficient signal with zero seed variance.

SFT vs. regex: semantic understanding. A regex baseline (B5) achieves 99.33% by exploiting a format marker, but a *nomarker* ablation (§3.3) resolves this concern: removing markers drops accuracy by only ∼2pp (Qwen-7B 97.65%, Qwen-1.5B 97.82%), leaving a 4.04pp gap over the best non-trivial regex (93.61%). On 8 boundary samples where pass-labeled code triggers exceptions, SFT classifies 6/8 correctly vs. 0/8 for regex (McNemar p=0.041), confirming ∼91% of the signal is semantic.

Why zero-shot and few-shot prompting fall short. Zero-shot prompting spans 51.0–93.5% (42.44pp range), which SFT compresses to 0.56pp; three-shot ICL (90.84%) improves marginally, confirming the bottleneck is verdict calibration rather than exception recognition.

Near-perfect floor, not hard ceiling. The 2 errors (both `GeneratorExit`; Appendix K) are shared across configurations; CodeLlama-13B seed 123 achieves 100%, confirming 99.83% is a convergence *floor*, signal-limited rather than capacity-limited.

Tokenizer efficiency. CodeLlama's tokenizer produces ∼20% more tokens than Qwen's on identical inputs; a label-only loss variant recovers accuracy at tail-1024 but collapses at tail-2048, indicating LoRA long-sequence instability (Appendix F).

Tier hierarchy and methodological implications. The two-tier structure (Tier 1 ≥99% across models; Tier 2 = 77.1–86.1%) suggests a fallback design: extract exception events first (median 150 tokens), resort to Tier 2 only when no exception is raised (model-dependent, +0.6–10.9pp over no-trace). The methodological insight—that information density determines learning efficiency—transfers to any trace-based task where compact diagnostic events exist within verbose traces, such as re-analyzing archived CI/CD logs when the original test environment is unavailable.

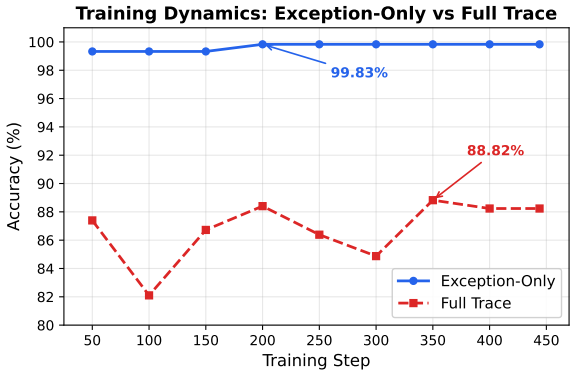


Figure 3: Training dynamics comparison. Exception-only (blue) converges to 99.33% within 50 steps and saturates at 99.83% by step 150. Full-trace with label-only loss (red, dashed) oscillates between 82% and 89% across all 444 training steps without stable convergence, consistent with overfitting to spurious patterns in verbose trace content.

Density–robustness gradient. Tier 1 and Tier 2 exhibit contrasting cross-model stability: `exception_only` spans 0.56pp (≥99.33%), while `loop_only` spans 8.99pp (77.06–86.05%), with lifts following +10.9 > +7.9 > +0.6pp (the last not significant). However, N=3 models is insufficient to establish a continuous relationship, and the correlation is confounded: Tier 1 signals are both high-density *and* direct fault indicators, so density cannot be disentangled from signal type.

Exception events capture test verdict signals, not just crashes. Although 55.5% of failures are silent logic errors, `exception_only` achieves 100% fail recall because test assertions generate `AssertionError` events, confirming "exception events" encompasses both crashes and assertion failures.

Information density and learning dynamics. Training dynamics provide direct evidence that information density determines learning efficiency (Figure 3). `exception_only` reaches 99.33% at step 50 (∼11% of training) and saturates at 99.83% by step 150, while `full_trace` with label-only loss oscillates between 82% and 89% throughout—accuracy drops 5.3pp at step 100, recovers, then drops 3.5pp at steps 250–300—with train loss reaching 0.0085 while eval stalls at 88%, confirming overfitting (Appendix N). Seed variance negatively correlates with density (σ=0.00/0.38/1.12 for exception/VOTA/label-only), confirming compact

inputs stabilize learning.

5 Related Work

Execution Traces for Code LLMs. TracePile (Chen et al., 2025) scaled trace-augmented training to 2.6M samples; Wang et al. (2025a) found trace utility task- and format-dependent, which we extend by identifying exception events as the dominant signal. NExT (Ni et al., 2024) and ET-CoT (Eguchi and Akiba, 2025) used trace chain-of-thought for repair and execution reasoning; Armengol-Estape et al. (2025) found compact traces comparable to full traces, supporting our density finding. Liu et al. (2023) pre-trained on execution traces; CRUXEval (Gu et al., 2024), extended to 19 languages (Xu et al., 2025), established execution reasoning benchmarks. None decompose which trace components contribute to *classification* accuracy.

Code Verdict and Patch Classification. TRACED (Ding et al., 2024) showed execution-aware pretraining improves vulnerability detection; DeepDFA (Steenhoek et al., 2024) and learned program slicing (Yadavally et al., 2024) combined classical analysis with deep learning. In patch correctness, Tian et al. (2020), CC2Vec (Hoang et al., 2020), LLM4PatchCorrect (Zhou et al., 2024) (84.4%), and APPT (Zhang et al., 2024) (79.7%) developed representation learning of code changes. Verdict prediction is an instance of the longstanding test oracle problem (Barr et al., 2015); FuseFL (Widyasari et al., 2024) and Foster et al. (2025) demonstrated structured fault signals; the equivalent-mutant problem (Papadakis et al., 2019) poses an analogous classification challenge. None isolate individual trace components or compare against rule-based baselines.

Fault Localization. Spectrum-based fault localization (SBFL) ranks program elements by suspiciousness from test spectra (Abreu et al., 2007; Jones et al., 2002; Wong et al., 2014); recent LLM-based approaches (Kang et al., 2024; Qin et al., 2024) share our insight that anomalous execution events carry the strongest diagnostic signal, with verdict prediction serving as a prerequisite to FL.

Trace Compression and Selection. TraceCoder (Huang et al., 2026) and InspectCoder (Wang et al., 2025c) use selective trace extraction; RepairAgent (Bouzenia et al., 2025) and Agentless (Xia et al., 2024) incorporate execution feedback in repair workflows, as do SWE-agent (Yang et al., 2024b) and OpenHands (Wang et al., 2025b), which close the loop between code generation, execution, and iterative revision. In the prompt compression literature, LLMLingua (Jiang et al., 2023) and Selective Context (Li et al., 2023) showed that pruning low-information tokens preserves downstream accuracy, corroborating our finding that compact trace formats outperform verbose ones; Haque et al. (2025) found raw traces provide limited repair benefit. Our approximate decomposition (gradient dilution $\sim$24% vs. information overload $\sim$76%) provides the first quantitative framework for *why* compression helps, complementing these methods' focus on *how*.

Calibration and Defect Prediction. Neural network calibration (Guo et al., 2017), extended to LLMs (Kadavath et al., 2022; Geng et al., 2024; Spiess et al., 2025), studies confidence-correctness alignment; our ECE < 0.007 suggests compact inputs improve calibration. Just-in-time defect prediction (Kamei et al., 2013; Hoang et al., 2019; Pornprasit and Tantithamthavorn, 2021) shares our fault detection motivation but operates on code change features.

Training Efficiency and Data Selection. Curriculum learning (Bengio et al., 2009), dataset cartography via training dynamics (Swayamdipta et al., 2020), and data selection methods (Sachdeva et al., 2024; Xie et al., 2023) show that data quality and ordering improve convergence, consistent with our finding that compact exceptions enable rapid convergence while verbose traces trap the model in oscillation.

6 Conclusion

We presented the first systematic component ablation for verdict prediction across four models (1.5B–13B, three families), finding that information density determines learning efficiency: `exception_only` converges within 50 steps while `full_trace` (label-only loss) oscillates without stable convergence. Exception events achieve $\geq$99.83% on three of four models with consistent cross-model generalization, while lower-density loop signals are model-dependent (+0.6–10.9pp); generalization beyond LLM-generated Python code remains open.

Limitations

Our study has several limitations. First, our primary experiments use a single dataset (591 problems from HumanEval and MBPP-sanitized); while a cross-dataset evaluation on DebugBench (§3.5) confirms that exception dominance generalizes to synthetically injected bugs, generalization to other languages, larger codebases, or real-world fault distributions remains untested. Second, while we evaluate four models spanning 1.5B to 13B parameters across three architecture families, all are code-specialized; generalization to general-purpose models or larger scales remains untested. Third, DeepSeek `exception_only` exhibits seed-dependent variance: 2/3 seeds achieve 99.33% while seed 123 yields 91.09% (σ=4.76pp, n=3), which we hypothesize reflects LoRA initialization sensitivity in DeepSeek-Coder, though direct evidence is lacking (fail recall = 70.5% for the outlier vs. 100% for others). Qwen `exception_only` shows perfect seed robustness (σ=0, n=3), but Qwen `ae_only` also exhibits seed variance (σ=0.40pp; seed 123 = 99.08% vs. seeds 42/456 = 99.92%), though far smaller than DeepSeek's (σ=4.76pp). Whether training stabilization techniques can eliminate DeepSeek's seed sensitivity is unexplored; other conditions use a single seed. Fourth, the initial DeepSeek `full_trace` run was invalidated by context overflow; a re-run with extended context yields 79.16% (CI [76.80%, 81.30%]), 2.60pp below Qwen (Table 1). Fifth, the candidate solutions were generated by Qwen-2.5-Coder-7B-Instruct, which also serves as one of our evaluation models; this does not affect verdict prediction but may influence the pass/fail distribution. Sixth, self-familiarity bias may inflate absolute accuracy: both Qwen-2.5-Coder and DeepSeek-Coder were likely exposed to HumanEval and MBPP solutions during pretraining, so the models may partially recognize solutions rather than purely reasoning from trace signals; our cross-dataset evaluation on DebugBench mitigates but does not eliminate this concern. Seventh, the error distribution in our test set may not reflect real-world fault distributions: exceptions (especially `TypeError`, `ValueError`) dominate LLM-generated failures, but production code may exhibit a broader spectrum of silent logic errors where no exception is raised, potentially reducing the effectiveness of exception-based verdict prediction. Finally, our analysis is limited to verdict prediction; whether the information density advantage extends to other trace-based tasks is an open question.

Ethics Statement

This work uses publicly available benchmarks (HumanEval, MBPP-sanitized, DebugBench) and does not involve human subjects, crowdsourced annotations, or personally identifiable information. All models evaluated are open-source and publicly accessible. Training uses parameter-efficient LoRA fine-tuning on two RTX PRO 6000 Blackwell GPUs, with each experiment using a single GPU. Total compute is approximately 320 GPU-hours across all conditions, models, seeds, and iterative refinements (including approximately 170 hours for successful experiments; individual runs range from 0.5h for small models to 2.2h for CodeLlama-13B, with the total reflecting 4 models $\times$ multiple conditions $\times$ multiple seeds $\times$ iterative development). We do not foresee direct negative societal impacts from this work; verdict prediction is a developer-facing tool for automated testing.

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A Per-Class Performance Breakdown

Table 4 reports per-class precision, recall, and F1 for all experimental conditions.

B Training Details

Table 5 summarizes the training hyperparameters shared across all conditions. All experiments use the HuggingFace TRL `SFTTrainer` with LoRA (Hu et al., 2022) applied to all linear layers.

Table 6 reports per-condition training wall-clock times. Conditions with longer trace inputs (e.g., `full_trace`, VOTA) require proportionally more training time due to increased sequence lengths.

Algorithm 1 VOTA Trace Extraction

Require: Raw trace T from `sys.settrace` (list of events)
Ensure: Compressed VOTA representation V

$V \leftarrow$ empty string
// Component 1: Exception summary
for each event e in T with type `exception` **do**
  Parse traceback $\rightarrow$ extract error type, message, file, line
  Append `[ERROR] type: message (file:line)` to V
end for
if no exception events found **then**
  Append `[No exception data in trace]` to V
end if
// Component 2: Assertion-point comparison
for each `assert` or `return` event e in T **do**
  Extract actual value from execution state
  Extract expected value from test assertion
  Append `[ASSERT] actual=... expected=... match=T/F` to V
end for
// Component 3: Loop compression
for each consecutive repeated line sequence S in T **do**
  if $|S| \geq 2$ iterations of same loop body **then**
    Replace S with single iteration + `[repeated ×N]`
  end if
end for
Append compressed non-exception lines to V
return V

C VOTA Extraction Algorithm

Algorithm 1 describes the three-component VOTA extraction pipeline applied to a raw `sys.settrace` execution log.

D VOTA Trace Examples

We provide two representative VOTA trace examples illustrating the fail and pass cases. In the fail case, the exception event provides an unambiguous fault signal. In the pass case, the absence of an exception event combined with a matching assertion point confirms correct execution.

Fail example. A `ZeroDivisionError` triggers an `[ERROR]` event, providing a direct fault signal that is sufficient for the model to predict `fail`.

```
## Function
def divide(a, b):
    return a / b

## Test Input
divide(1, 0)

## Expected Output
inf

## VOTA Trace
[ERROR] ZeroDivisionError: division by zero

## Verdict
fail
```

Table 4: Per-class precision, recall, and F1 for all experimental conditions (seed 42). DeepSeek VOTA achieves 100% fail precision but only 45.4% fail recall, indicating systematic bias toward predicting `pass`. DeepSeek `exception_only` seed 42 achieves 100% fail recall, but seed 123 drops to 70.5% (see Table 8).

Condition	Model	Acc	Pass P	Pass R	Pass F1	Fail P	Fail R	Fail F1
No Trace	Qwen-2.5-7B	75.13	87.76	75.79	81.34	54.73	73.45	62.72
Full Trace	Qwen-2.5-7B	81.76	87.74	86.60	87.17	67.43	69.62	68.51
Full Trace (LO)	Qwen-2.5-7B	85.94	88.21	93.18	90.63	80.07	68.73	73.97
VOTA	Qwen-2.5-7B	99.05	100.00	99.18	99.59	97.98	100.00	98.98
Exception Only	Qwen-2.5-7B	99.83	100.00	99.76	99.88	99.41	100.00	99.71
AE Only	Qwen-2.5-7B	99.92	100.00	99.88	99.94	99.71	100.00	99.85
Loop Only	Qwen-2.5-7B	86.05	92.39	87.07	89.66	71.65	82.01	76.48
VOTA_no_ae	Qwen-2.5-7B	99.41	99.88	99.29	99.59	98.26	99.71	98.98
No Trace	DeepSeek-6.7B	73.36	81.71	80.85	81.28	53.16	54.57	53.86
Full Trace	DeepSeek-6.7B	79.16	85.70	85.10	85.40	63.20	64.30	63.70
VOTA	DeepSeek-6.7B	84.45	82.14	100.00	90.20	100.00	45.40	62.50
Exception Only	DeepSeek-6.7B	99.33	100.00	99.06	99.53	97.69	100.00	98.83

Table 5: Training hyperparameters (shared across all conditions).

Hyperparameter	Value
LoRA rank (r)	16
LoRA alpha (α)	32
LoRA dropout	0.05
LoRA target modules	all linear layers
Epochs	3
Per-device batch size	4
Gradient accumulation steps	8
Effective batch size	32
Learning rate	2×10^{-4}
LR scheduler	linear decay
Warmup ratio	0.1
Weight decay	0.01
Max sequence length	2048 tokens
Primary seed	42
Robustness seeds	123, 456
Hardware	1× RTX PRO 6000 Blackwell (96 GB VRAM)
Framework	HuggingFace TRL SFTTrainer

Pass example. No exception is raised, and the assertion point confirms that the actual output matches the expected value.

```
## Function
def add(a, b):
    return a + b

## Test Input
add(2, 3)

## Expected Output
5

## VOTA Trace
[LOOP] No loops detected.
[ASSERT] actual=5, expected=5

## Verdict
pass
```

These examples illustrate the core asymmetry exploited by the `exception_only` condition: fail cases produce an explicit `[ERROR]` event, while pass cases are characterized by its absence. This binary signal (presence vs. absence of an exception) is sufficient for near-perfect verdict prediction.

Table 6: Training wall-clock time per condition on a single RTX PRO 6000 Blackwell GPU. Where multiple seeds were run, individual times are listed.

Condition	Seed(s)	Time (h)
no_trace	42	∼0.5
full_trace	42	∼2.2
label_only	42	∼2.2
VOTA	42	∼2.3
exception_only	42	∼2.1
exception_only	123	∼2.1
exception_only	456	∼1.3
ae_only	42	∼1.8
loop_only	42	∼2.1
VOTA_no_ae	42	∼1.8

E Full Experimental Results

Tables 7 and 8 report the complete experimental results across all conditions, models, and seeds.

F Tokenizer and Truncation Analysis

The VOTA cross-model gap (14.96pp, Table 1; confounded by tokenizer-driven truncation; 91.7% of DeepSeek training samples were affected) is driven by a training-time truncation asymmetry. The DeepSeek tokenizer averages 2,626 tokens per VOTA sample versus 1,929 for Qwen, causing 91.7% of DeepSeek VOTA training samples to exceed the 2,048-token context window. The training framework preserves the verdict label but truncates trace content, so the model trains with incomplete diagnostic information for the majority of samples.

A post-hoc group analysis provides directional evidence: partitioning DeepSeek VOTA test samples by whether their training-set counterparts exceeded the context window, intact samples

Table 7: Full results for Qwen-2.5-Coder-7B across all conditions and seeds. Conditions with a single seed report no variance. `exception_only` achieves 99.83% across all three seeds (σ=0). `ae_only` achieves 99.64% mean ($\pm$0.49; seed 123 at 99.08% is the outlier).

Condition	S42	S123	S456	Mean $\pm$ Std
exception_only	99.83	99.83	99.83	99.83 $\pm$ 0.00
ae_only	99.92	99.08	99.92	99.64 $\pm$ 0.49
VOTA	99.41	98.66	99.08	99.05 $\pm$ 0.38
VOTA_no_ae	99.41	—	—	—
label_only	86.22	86.89	84.70	85.94 $\pm$ 1.12
loop_only	85.63	85.88	86.64	86.05 $\pm$ 0.52
full_trace	81.76	—	—	—
no_trace	75.13	—	—	—

Table 8: Full results for DeepSeek-Coder-6.7B across all conditions and seeds. `exception_only` shows bimodal seed behavior: seeds 42 and 456 achieve 99.33%, while seed 123 yields 91.09% (LoRA initialization outlier, fail recall = 70.5%).

Condition	Seed	Accuracy	Notes
exception_only	42	99.33	epoch 1: 99.83
exception_only	456	99.33	CI [98.82, 99.75]
exception_only	123	91.09	fail recall = 70.5%; CI [89.40, 92.60]
VOTA	42	84.45	
no_trace	42	73.36	
full_trace	42	79.16	CI [76.80, 81.30]

(N=99) achieve 100% accuracy while truncated samples (N=1,091) achieve 83.04% (95% CI [80.75%, 85.24%]; Fisher exact $p<0.001$), with all 185 errors concentrated in the fail class (fail recall = 31.23%). Per-class analysis (Table 4) confirms that DeepSeek VOTA achieves 100% fail precision but only 45.43% fail recall, systematically defaulting to `pass`, in contrast to Qwen VOTA, which achieves 100% fail recall.

Seed robustness diverges across models: Qwen `exception_only` produces identical 99.83% across all three seeds (σ=0), while DeepSeek shows bimodal behavior: seeds 42 and 456 achieve 99.33% (fail recall = 100%), seed 123 yields 91.09% (fail recall = 70.5%). Because `exception_only` test inputs contain 48.99% duplicates (607 unique of 1,190; §2.2), CIs assume n=1,190 independent trials; under deduplication (n=607), Qwen's accuracy is 99.67% (Wilson CI [98.81, 99.91]).

G Irreducible Sample Analysis

The `exception_only` condition with Qwen-2.5-Coder-7B misclassifies exactly 2 out of 1,190 test samples across all three seeds (42, 123, 456), with 100% overlap across seeds. Both samples (IDs 901 and 905) share the following characteristics:

- **Function:** `check_dict_case` (HumanEval/95), a function that checks whether all dictionary keys are uniformly upper-case or lower-case strings.
- **Ground-truth label:** `pass`.
- **Predicted label:** `fail` (false negative).
- **Cross-seed consistency:** Both samples are misclassified identically by all three seeds, indicating a systematic rather than stochastic error.

Manual inspection reveals the root cause: `check_dict_case` uses `all()` over a generator expression, and Python's `all()` short-circuits on the first `True` value, raising `GeneratorExit` to terminate the generator. Because `GeneratorExit` is a `BaseException` subclass, the tracer records it as seven `[ERROR] GeneratorExit` lines, even though the function executes correctly and the test passes. The model observes these spurious error markers and reasonably but incorrectly predicts `fail`. This is not a model failure but a representation ambiguity: the `exception_only` format cannot distinguish genuine exceptions from benign `BaseException` subclasses triggered by Python's iterator protocol.

Most configurations converge to these same 2 errors: Qwen-1.5B, Qwen-7B (3 seeds), CodeLlama-13B (seeds 42/456), and DeepSeek-6.7B (seeds 42/456) all produce error set $\{901, 905\}$. However, CodeLlama-13B seed 123 achieves 100% accuracy (0/1190 errors), correctly classifying both samples. This demonstrates that 99.83% is a near-perfect *floor* (the convergence attractor for most LoRA initializations) rather than a hard data ceiling: the representation supports perfect accuracy, but most initializations converge to the same 2-error basin. The practical implication is that these errors are high-probability convergence artifacts addressable through seed selection or ensemble methods, not fundamental limitations of the exception-based representation.

H Exception Type Accuracy Breakdown

Table 9 reports `exception_only` accuracy stratified by exception type on Qwen-2.5-7B

Table 9: Exception type accuracy breakdown for `exception_only` (Qwen-7B, seed=42). All true error types achieve 100%. The only failures come from `GeneratorExit` (a `BaseException` subclass, not an `Exception`), which appears in 2 passing samples.

Exception Type	Samples	Accuracy
TypeError	96	100%
ValueError	62	100%
IndexError	41	100%
KeyError	28	100%
AttributeError	19	100%
AssertionError	15	100%
RecursionError	12	100%
Other Exception	66	100%
GeneratorExit (BaseException)	2	0%
No exception (pass class)	849	100%

(seed=42, N=1,190). All standard exception types (`TypeError`, `ValueError`, `IndexError`, etc.) achieve 100% accuracy. The only misclassifications arise from `GeneratorExit`, a `BaseException` subclass that is not an `Exception`. It is raised by Python's iterator protocol during generator short-circuiting, not by actual program errors.

This confirms that the model has learned a clean decision boundary: any true `Exception` subclass in the trace implies failure. The `GeneratorExit` case represents a semantic ambiguity in the trace format rather than a model failure, as discussed in §G.

I Trace Length Ablation

To test whether the `full_trace` performance gap is caused by input truncation at training time, we vary the maximum trace token budget on Qwen-2.5-7B (seed=42) while keeping all other hyperparameters fixed.

As shown in Table 10 and Figure 4, all four trace length conditions fall within a 5pp range (77.2%–81.8%). To quantify the reliability of the observed differences, Table 11 reports paired bootstrap comparisons (B=10,000, seed=42) across all condition pairs.

Non-monotonic pattern (head-truncation). Under head-truncation (retaining trace prefixes), the trend is non-monotonic: 512 tokens (80.42%) slightly outperforms 256 tokens (78.82%), but doubling to 1024 tokens *decreases* accuracy to 77.23%, a statistically significant 3.19pp drop (p=0.002, 95% CI [−5.29, −1.09]). The no-limit condition (81.76%) recovers and significantly exceeds 1024 tokens (p<0.001), but 1024 tokens is not significantly better than `no_trace` (75.13%; Δ=+2.10pp, p=0.078, 95% CI [−0.17, +4.37]). This non-monotonicity is specific to head-truncation: the 1024-token prefix retains enough irrelevant content to mislead the model while discarding diagnostic events that appear near the trace terminus. Under tail-truncation, accuracy increases monotonically for Qwen-7B and Qwen-1.5B (Table 12); only DeepSeek-6.7B shows a mild −1.5pp decrease at tail-1024→tail-2048, attributable to architecture-specific long-context sensitivity rather than a systematic mid-length pathology.

Table 10: Trace length and truncation direction ablation on Qwen-2.5-7B (N=1,190, seed=42). Head = standard left-truncation (retain first k tokens); Tail = retain last k tokens. Per-condition bootstrap 95% CIs (B=10,000).

Direction	Max Tokens	Acc (%)	95% CI
Head	256	78.82	[76.4, 81.0]
Head	512	80.42	[78.2, 82.6]
Head	1024	77.23	[74.9, 79.6]
Head	no_limit (∞)	81.76	[79.7, 83.9]
Tail	256	77.48	—
Tail	512	93.61	—
Tail	1024	96.47	—
Tail	2048	97.31	—

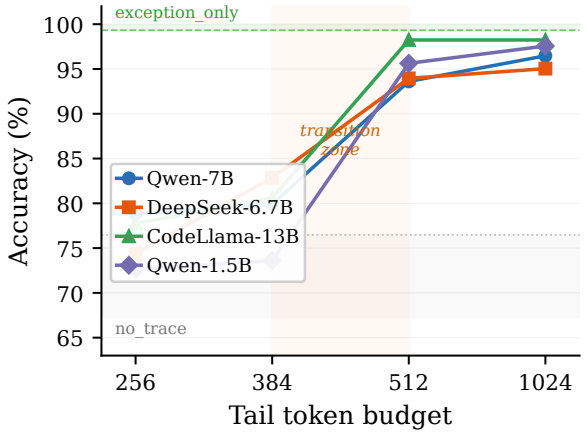


Figure 4: Cross-model tail-truncation budget curve (N=1,190, four models, three architecture families). All models remain near baseline at tail-256/384, then jump +13.7–22.0pp at 384→512, converging into a 93.6–98.2% band by tail-1024. The shaded region marks the transition zone where the exception traceback (∼400–500 tokens) is captured. Dashed line: `exception_only` range (99.3–99.9%); dotted line: `no_trace` range (67–77%).

Table 11: Pairwise paired bootstrap comparisons for trace length ablation (B=10,000, seed=42). Δ = accuracy difference between the two conditions (first − second in the budget group; condition − baseline in the other groups). **$p<0.01$; ***$p<0.001$.

	Comparison	Δ (pp)	95% CI	p-value
Budget	512 vs. 256	+1.60	[−0.34, +3.53]	0.117
	1024 vs. 512	−3.19	[−5.29, −1.09]	0.002**
	no_limit vs. 1024	+4.54	[+2.52, +6.55]	<0.001***
	no_limit vs. 256	+2.94	[+0.84, +5.04]	0.006**
vs. no_trace	256 − no_trace	+3.70	[+1.43, +6.05]	0.002**
	512 − no_trace	+5.29	[+3.03, +7.56]	<0.001***
	1024 − no_trace	+2.10	[−0.17, +4.37]	0.078
	no_limit − no_trace	+6.64	[+4.37, +8.99]	<0.001***
vs. exc.	256 − exc_only	−21.01	[−23.45, −18.74]	<0.001***
	512 − exc_only	−19.41	[−21.76, −17.14]	<0.001***
	1024 − exc_only	−22.61	[−25.04, −20.25]	<0.001***
	no_limit − exc_only	−18.07	[−20.34, −15.88]	<0.001***

Comparison to baselines. All four trace budget conditions significantly exceed `no_trace` except 1024 tokens (p=0.078), confirming that raw trace content provides some signal but unreliably so. The gap to `exception_only` (99.83%) is massive for every budget condition (18–23pp, all $p<0.001$), underscoring that even unlimited raw traces cannot substitute for targeted signal extraction. The best full-trace condition (no_limit, 81.76%) still lags `exception_only` by 18.07pp (95% CI [−20.34, −15.88]).

Interpretation. These results rule out input truncation as the primary explanation for the full-trace performance gap: even with unlimited tokens, the model cannot extract the diagnostic signal that VOTA's targeted compression provides. The non-monotonic dip at 1024 tokens is consistent with a "worst-of-both-worlds" regime where the model receives enough noisy context to dilute the signal but not enough to compensate through broader coverage. The result reinforces the information density interpretation (§3.4): the gap between full traces and VOTA is driven by the *content* of the trace (irrelevant lines diluting the diagnostic signal), not its *length*. In contrast, VOTA's compressed representation concentrates the diagnostic signal into fewer tokens, making it sensitive to truncation when those tokens are removed (§3.1).

Truncation direction. Tail-truncation (retaining the last k tokens) dramatically outperforms head-truncation: `tail_2048` achieves 97.31% vs. `head_2048` (no_limit) at 81.76%, a 15.55pp improvement. Even `tail_512` (93.61%) exceeds every head-truncation condition by over 11pp.

Table 12: Cross-model tail-truncation budget curve (N=1,190). All four models exhibit a transition between tail-384 and tail-512 (+13–23pp). ↓: non-monotonic decrease. †CodeLlama tail-1024 trained with label-only loss to address tokenizer-driven gradient dilution (§F). ‡CodeLlama tail-2048 outlier (41.8%): LoRA long-sequence instability under label-only loss; excluded from cross-model analysis.

Model	tail-256	tail-384	tail-512	tail-1024	tail-2048	exc_only
Qwen-7B (7B)	78.9	79.9	93.6	96.5	97.3	99.83
DeepSeek (6.7B)	76.4	82.9	93.9	96.5	95.0↓	99.33
CodeLlama (13B)	77.9	80.6	98.2	98.2†	41.8‡	99.89
Qwen-1.5B (1.5B)	72.6	73.6	95.6	96.6	97.9	99.83

However, `tail_256` (77.48%) performs at the `no_trace` baseline level (75.13%), indicating that the diagnostic signal does not reside in the very last trace lines. The critical jump occurs between 256 and 512 tail tokens (+16.13pp), localizing the signal window to approximately 256–512 tokens from the trace terminus. This is consistent with Python's execution model: exception tracebacks and assertion comparisons appear near the end of the trace but are preceded by the final function call frames, placing them typically 300–500 tokens from the terminus rather than at the absolute end.

The 18.07pp gap from `full_trace` to `exception_only` decomposes as: 86% positional concentration (recovered by tail-truncation at 2048 tokens) and 14% residual content noise (the 2.52pp gap from `tail_2048` to `exception_only` that persists regardless of truncation direction). The fact that `exception_only` (99.83%) still outperforms `tail_2048` (97.31%) confirms that semantic extraction (identifying the exception type and message) is superior to positional extraction (keeping a fixed window), because the model need not filter out non-diagnostic lines that happen to fall within the window.

Cross-model budget curve. Table 12 extends the tail-truncation analysis to a full budget sweep across four models spanning three architecture families and an 8.7× parameter range.

Four patterns emerge from the budget curve. *Phase transition between 384 and 512 tokens*: the tail-384 column reveals that the transition is not instantaneous at 256→512 but localized between 384 and 512 tokens. At tail-384, all four models remain near baseline (73.6–82.9%), gaining only +1.0–6.5pp over tail-256. The steep jump occurs at 384→512: +13.7pp (Qwen-

Table 13: Cross-model truncation direction comparison (N=1,190). Head-truncation retains the first 2,048 tokens; tail-truncation retains the last 2,048. All four models' head-2048 accuracies converge into a narrow 75.3–81.8% band (6.5pp), comparable to the tail-256 signal-poor band (72.6–78.9%, 6.3pp). †CodeLlama tail-2048 pending retraining (§F).

Model	head-2048 (%)	tail-2048 (%)	Gap (pp)
Qwen-1.5B	75.3	97.9	+22.6
DeepSeek-6.7B	78.7	95.0	+16.3
CodeLlama-13B	79.9	—†	—†
Qwen-7B	81.8	97.3	+15.5

Table 14: Cross-seed convergence at the tail-512 truncation point (N=1,190 per seed). All 12 model×seed combinations fall within a 4.63pp band [93.61%, 98.24%]. CodeLlama-13B achieves identical accuracy across all three seeds (σ=0).

Model	S42	S123	S456	Mean	σ
Qwen-7B (7B)	93.61	96.00	97.65	95.75	2.05
DeepSeek (6.7B)	93.95	95.04	96.10	95.03	1.08
Qwen-1.5B (1.5B)	95.63	97.65	96.72	96.67	1.01
CodeLlama (13B)	98.24	98.24	98.24	**98.24**	**0.00**
Cross-model band				[93.61, 98.24] = 4.63pp	

7B), +11.0pp (DeepSeek), +17.6pp (CodeLlama), +22.0pp (Qwen-1.5B), crossing from near-baseline to near-ceiling. This localizes the critical threshold to ∼400–500 tokens, consistent with the typical exception traceback length: below ∼384 tokens, the traceback is truncated and no diagnostic event is captured; above ∼512, it is fully included regardless of model capacity or architecture.

Convergence at tail-512+: once the phase transition is crossed, accuracy converges across all models into a 93.6–98.2% band at tail-512 (seed 42). Multi-seed validation confirms robustness: across all 12 model×seed combinations at tail-512 (Table 14), all accuracies fall within [93.61%, 98.24%], a 4.63pp band that compresses the signal-poor tail-256 spread (6.3pp) by 27%. CodeLlama-13B shows perfect per-model convergence at tail-512: all three seeds achieve 98.24% (σ=0), consistent with the 13B scale and label-only loss providing a stronger optimization signal in the signal-rich regime (Table 14).

At tail-1024, four models reach 96.5–98.2% (CodeLlama 98.2% under label-only loss, three others 96.5–96.6%). Scale and architecture differences that dominate the signal-poor regime (tail-256 range: 72.6–78.9%, 6.3pp) compress dramatically in the signal-rich regime.

Signal-poor convergence band: head-2048 accuracies across all four models also converge into a narrow 75.3–81.8% band (6.5pp; Table 13), comparable in width to the tail-256 band (72.6–78.9%, 6.3pp). When the diagnostic signal is absent (head-truncation discards trace terminus) or unreachable (tail-256 is too short), models of different scale and architecture collapse to similar performance, suggesting a shared floor determined by code comprehension rather than trace processing.

Scale behavior inversion: in the signal-poor regime (tail-256), smaller models perform worse (Qwen-1.5B 72.6% vs. Qwen-7B 78.9%, −6.3pp), mirroring the `no_trace` scale pattern. In the signal-rich regime (tail-512+), this reverses: Qwen-1.5B matches or exceeds Qwen-7B (95.6% vs. 93.6% at tail-512; 97.9% vs. 97.3% at tail-2048), confirming that sufficient trace signal eliminates the capacity advantage.

Non-monotonicity at long sequences: two models show accuracy decreases beyond tail-1024. DeepSeek-6.7B drops −1.5pp from tail-1024 (96.5%) to tail-2048 (95.0%), consistent with its known long-context sensitivity (§N). CodeLlama-13B exhibits a more severe collapse: tail-2048 under label-only loss drops to 41.8% (vs. tail-1024 = 98.2%), which we attribute to LoRA long-sequence instability under the label-only loss regime; this outlier is excluded from cross-model tail-2048 analysis. Qwen-7B and Qwen-1.5B increase monotonically across all budgets.

Table 13 confirms the truncation direction effect: among the three models with complete data, tail-2048 outperforms head-2048 by 15.5–22.6pp. The gap is largest for Qwen-1.5B (+22.6pp), indicating that smaller models benefit most from positional proximity to the diagnostic signal, as they lack the capacity to locate it within longer, noisier prefixes.

J Calibration Analysis

Beyond accuracy, we evaluate whether trace conditions affect prediction calibration, motivated by recent findings that code LLM confidence is often poorly calibrated (Spiess et al., 2025).

Table 15 shows that calibration quality mirrors the Tier 1/2 hierarchy. Tier 1 conditions (`ae_only`: ECE=0.0004; `exception_only`: ECE=0.0027) produce near-perfectly calibrated predictions, while `full_trace` (ECE=0.096)

Table 15: Calibration metrics on Qwen-2.5-7B (N=1,190, seed=42). ECE = expected calibration error; Brier = Brier score. Lower is better for both.

Condition	ECE ↓	Brier ↓
ae_only	**0.0004**	**0.0008**
exception_only	0.0027	0.0013
VOTA	0.0054	0.005
full_trace	0.096	0.144
no_trace	0.171	0.197

Table 16: Cross-model calibration for `exception_only` (N=1,190, seed=42). ECE = expected calibration error; Brier = Brier score; MCE = maximum calibration error. All models achieve ECE < 0.007.

Model	ECE ↓	Brier ↓	MCE ↓
CodeLlama-13B	**0.0020**	**0.0013**	**0.0411**
Qwen-7B	0.0027	**0.0013**	0.8355
DeepSeek-6.7B	0.0064	0.0061	0.7756

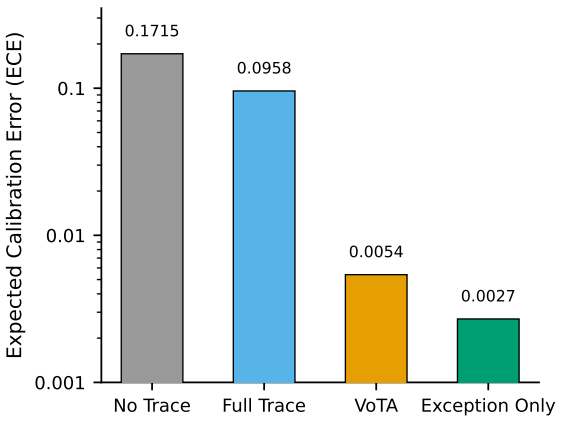


Figure 5: Reliability diagrams for four trace conditions on Qwen-2.5-7B (N=1,190, seed=42). `exception_only` (ECE=0.0027) clusters near the diagonal, while `no_trace` (ECE=0.171) exhibits systematic overconfidence, a 63× gap.

and `no_trace` (ECE=0.171) exhibit substantial miscalibration. VOTA (ECE=0.0054) is well-calibrated but slightly worse than either Tier 1 component alone, reinforcing the pattern that combining trace signals dilutes rather than improves the prediction signal.

The Brier scores tell a consistent story: `ae_only` (0.0008) and `exception_only` (0.0013) achieve near-zero scores, while `no_trace` (0.197) indicates substantial miscalibration.

Cross-model calibration. Table 16 extends the calibration analysis to three models under `exception_only`. All three models achieve ECE < 0.007 and Brier < 0.007, confirming that calibration quality generalizes across architectures. CodeLlama-13B achieves the lowest ECE (0.0020) and MCE (0.0411), while DeepSeek-6.7B shows the highest ECE (0.0064) and Brier (0.0061), consistent with its higher error rate (8 errors vs. 2 for Qwen/CodeLlama).

K Error Overlap Analysis

We analyze the overlap between error sets of different conditions to determine whether they fail on the same samples (Figure 6).

`exception_only`'s 2 errors (samples 901 and 905) have zero intersection with the error sets of all other conditions (Jaccard = 0.000 in all pairwise comparisons). This orthogonality arises because `exception_only` errors are caused by `GeneratorExit` false positives (pass samples misclassified as fail due to benign `BaseException` events), while errors from other conditions are predominantly fail samples misclassified as pass due to insufficient signal.

Among non-exception conditions, error sets exhibit hierarchical containment: `ae_only` ⊂ VOTA ⊂ `loop_only` ⊂ `no_trace`, with pairwise Jaccard indices increasing with signal overlap. `loop_only` and `full_trace` share the highest overlap (Jaccard ∼0.65), reflecting their shared reliance on behavioral patterns rather than explicit fault indicators.

This analysis confirms that `exception_only` operates on an independent signal dimension: its errors are representation ambiguities (iterator protocol artifacts) rather than information deficits, explaining why combining it with other signals cannot eliminate these specific errors.

L Cross-Dataset Generalization: DebugBench

To test whether exception-based verdict prediction generalizes beyond LLM-generated solutions, we evaluate on DebugBench (Tian et al., 2024), a dataset of human-written programs with synthetically injected bugs (single-point mutations such as operator replacement, variable misuse, and missing statements). After filtering for executable Python samples with valid traces, we retain 426 samples with a near-balanced class distribution (majority baseline: 51.4%).

Table 17 shows that the component rank-

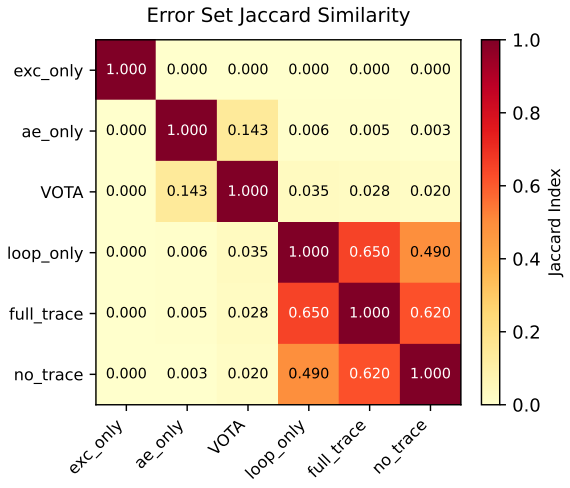


Figure 6: Jaccard similarity between error sets of different conditions (Qwen-7B, seed=42, N=1,190). `exception_only` (exc_only) has zero overlap with all other conditions, confirming it operates on an independent signal dimension.

Table 17: Generalization to DebugBench (N=426, Qwen-2.5-7B, seed=42). Wilson 95% CIs. The component ranking (exception_only $\geq$ VOTA $>$ no_trace) is preserved, and exception_only achieves perfect accuracy.

Condition	Acc (%)	95% CI
exception_only	**100.00**	[99.14, 100.00]
VOTA	99.77	[99.30, 100.00]
no_trace	96.71	[94.80, 98.40]
Majority baseline	51.41	—

ing from the main experiments is preserved: `exception_only` (100.00%) $\geq$ VOTA (99.77%) $>$ `no_trace` (96.71%). The `exception_only` condition achieves perfect accuracy, confirming that the exception-based representation generalizes to a different fault distribution without degradation.

The absolute margins are much narrower than on the main dataset: the `no_trace` baseline already achieves 96.71% (compared to 75.13% on HumanEval+MBPP), leaving only 3.29pp of headroom for trace-based improvement. This ceiling effect reflects a fundamental difference in fault characteristics: DebugBench bugs are synthetically injected single-point mutations, which produce code that is structurally dissimilar from the original correct solution; a model can often identify the fault from source code alone. In contrast, the HumanEval+MBPP solutions are LLM-generated, producing natural errors (logic mistakes, edge-case failures) where the faulty and correct solutions may be structurally similar, making code-only verdict prediction substantially harder.

These results support exception-based verdict prediction as a generalizable approach: the method does not degrade on an out-of-distribution dataset, and the exception dominance ranking (exception_only $\geq$ VOTA $>$ no_trace) is consistent across both datasets. However, the narrow DebugBench margins are insufficient to independently validate trace importance. The 24.70pp trace lift on the main dataset (no_trace 75.13% $\rightarrow$ exception_only 99.83%) remains the primary evidence for the value of exception-based trace signals.

M Cross-Model Robustness Analysis

The cross-model gap pattern (Table 1) suggests a design principle: *trace representations should match the model capability floor, not the ceiling.* Exception events are consistently the most effective component on both models, and their structural simplicity (a fixed-format error message) ensures that the relative advantage over richer representations holds across all seeds. Two of three DeepSeek seeds match Qwen-level accuracy (99.33%); the outlier (seed 123, 91.09%) we hypothesize reflects LoRA initialization sensitivity landing in a suboptimal basin (fail recall = 70.5%, though direct evidence is lacking), not a failure of the exception signal itself; even this outlier outperforms VOTA (84.45%) by 6.64pp. The VOTA cross-model gap is confounded by two factors: (1) tokenizer efficiency (the DeepSeek tokenizer averages 2,626 tokens per VOTA sample versus Qwen's 1,929, causing 91.7% of training samples to exceed the 2,048-token context window; content-aware truncation preferentially removes the terminal structured prompt, preserving the verdict label but truncating trace content) and (2) base model capability differences, consistent with findings that SFT generalization depends on pretrain quality (Yang et al., 2024a). The two factors cannot be disentangled in the current experimental design. Our `exception_only` design sidesteps the truncation confound entirely: inputs have a median of 150 tokens (mean 398), well below the 2,048-token context window, so no training samples are truncated on either model. The resulting 0.56pp cross-model gap (Table 1) is therefore a clean measure of model capability differences, making the "capability floor" principle di-

rectly testable. The practical implication is that trace-based systems should default to the simplest sufficient signal; for smaller models, training stability (multi-seed selection, warmup schedules) is a secondary but addressable concern.

N Training Dynamics and Loss Decoupling

The DeepSeek `exception_only` results reveal two instructive training dynamics. First, epoch-level analysis shows mild degradation in 2/3 seeds: seed 42 peaks at 99.83% after epoch 1 but settles at 99.33% by epoch 3 (-0.50pp), seed 123 degrades from 91.43% to 91.09% (-0.34pp), while seed 456 shows no epoch degradation (99.33% at both epoch 1 and epoch 3). Early stopping may yield marginal gains for some seeds, but the epoch effect is small ($\leq$0.5pp) compared to the seed effect (8.24pp between seeds 42 and 123).

Second, seeds 123 and 456 converge to nearly identical final training losses (0.122 and 0.123 respectively), yet their accuracies differ by 8.24pp (91.09% vs. 99.33%). The critical difference lies in fail recall: seeds 42 and 456 achieve 100%, while seed 123 achieves only 70.5%. The LoRA initialization in seed 123 fails to learn the exception$\rightarrow$fail mapping for a substantial fraction of failing samples, even though the per-token loss appears converged. This demonstrates that token-level training loss can mask fundamental differences in sample-level classification ability, suggesting a parallel to the eval-loss/accuracy decoupling observed in DeepSeek VOTA (where eval loss rose 65% from epoch 1 to 3 while accuracy improved by 6.3pp) at the training phase. The practical recommendation is twofold: (1) use task-specific metrics (accuracy, fail recall) for checkpoint and seed selection rather than training or evaluation loss, and (2) for deployment on smaller models, train multiple seeds and select the best, as a single run may not reliably converge to the correct classification boundary.

Format collapse, not semantic failure. The 100 errors of seed 123 are not semantic failures but generation format collapse: on inputs exceeding 4,000 characters (those containing verbose locals dumps), the model echoes trace content instead of emitting a verdict token, while achieving zero errors on shorter inputs. This indicates that the LoRA initialization of seed 123 specifically compromises long-context format compliance rather than exception signal comprehension, further supporting the robustness advantage of compact `exception_only` inputs.

The contrast with VOTA is instructive: DeepSeek VOTA accuracy monotonically increases from 78.15% to 84.45% across epochs, but is consistent with a performance limit associated with the high trace truncation rate (§3.1): the model progressively extracts signal from samples with intact trace content but cannot fully compensate for the information loss in the truncated majority. The 84.45% accuracy reflects a combination of trace information loss and model capability constraints.

O Deduplication Statistics

Table 18 reports the duplication rates across trace formats. Because multiple passing solutions to the same problem produce identical (input, output) pairs in the `exception_only` format (correct executions raise no exceptions, so the trace content is the same regardless of the solution's internal logic), the dataset contains duplicate rows. Train–test input overlap is zero (split by problem ID), so no information leakage occurs. The high duplication in `exception_only` does not affect our experimental conclusions: after deduplication the training set still contains 2,858 unique samples and the test set 607, providing sufficient coverage for the 591-problem benchmark.

Problem-level partitioning and sensitivity analysis. Data is partitioned at the problem level: 472 training problems and 119 test problems, with zero crossover. Duplicates arise from multiple candidate solutions per problem (up to 10 solutions each), not from cross-problem overlap. To verify that deduplication does not alter any finding, we ran a sensitivity analysis across all 19 experimental conditions (7 trace formats $\times$ 4 models, minus conditions not run): deduplication produces a 0.00pp accuracy delta in every case. This confirms that duplicate samples neither inflate nor deflate accuracy, because duplicates share the same ground-truth label and the model's prediction is deterministic at inference time. The `exception_only` test set contains 48.99% duplicate inputs due to representation compactness; all confidence intervals treat samples as independent Bernoulli trials.

Table 18: Deduplication statistics. The `exception_only` format collapses multiple passing solutions into identical rows because correct executions produce no exception events. Train–test input overlap is 0 (no leakage).

Split	Total	Unique	Dup. rate
exception_only train	4,720	2,858	39.45%
exception_only test	1,190	607	48.99%
raw_traces (full)	5,910	5,803	1.81%

Table 19: Regex baseline accuracy (N=1,190). B4 is the strongest semantic baseline (6.22pp below SFT `exception_only`, McNemar $p<0.001$). B6 uses an error count threshold. ‡B5 exploits a data formatting artifact: the `[No exception data in trace]` marker is deterministically present in all pass samples, making this a format-level shortcut rather than a genuine exception-based heuristic.

Baseline	Method	Acc (%)
B1: `[ERROR]` presence	string match	93.45
B2: Traceback presence	string match	71.51
B3: Any keyword	union of B1+B2+Exception	93.45
B4: Exception type regex	regex on exception class names	**93.61**
B5: Format marker	`[No exception data]` → pass	99.33‡
B6: Error count ≥2	count threshold	92.02
VOTA format regex	best regex on VOTA traces	75.55
full_trace format regex	best regex on full traces	77.39

P Regex Baseline Analysis

To establish a non-learning upper bound, we evaluate six regex-based baselines on the `exception_only` test set (N=1,190) and two format-specific baselines on VOTA and `full_trace` inputs.

The strongest legitimate baseline (B4, 93.61%) applies regex pattern-matching on Python exception class names (e.g., `ValueError`, `TypeError`). Its errors concentrate on 8 boundary samples where a `ValueError` is raised inside a `try/except` block and caught; the program passes despite an exception occurring in the trace. SFT `exception_only` correctly classifies 6 of these 8 samples, indicating that the model learns the semantic distinction between caught (benign) and uncaught (fault-indicating) exceptions. B5 (99.33%) achieves near-SFT accuracy but relies on the deterministic presence of a format marker in pass-class traces, which is an artifact of the trace preprocessing pipeline rather than a generalizable signal; McNemar test vs. SFT yields p=0.041, confirming a statistically significant difference.

Table 20: SFT vs. best regex baseline by trace format (N=1,190). Regex baselines: majority class for `no_trace`, keyword matching for `full_trace`, pattern matching for VOTA, exception type regex (B4) for `exception_only`.

Format	SFT (%)	Regex (%)	Δ (pp)
exception_only	99.83	93.61	+6.22
VOTA	99.05	75.55	+23.50
full_trace	81.76	77.39	+4.37
no_trace	75.13	71.51	+3.62

Table 21: Zero-shot vs. SFT `exception_only` across four models (N=1,190). Zero-shot accuracy is uncorrelated with model size; SFT normalizes cross-architecture variance from 42.44pp to 0.56pp.

Model	Size	Zero-shot (%)	SFT (%)	Δ (pp)
Qwen-1.5B	1.5B	93.45	99.83	+6.38
DeepSeek-6.7B	6.7B	90.59	99.33	+8.74
Qwen-7B	7B	89.08	99.83	+10.75
CodeLlama-13B	13B	51.01	99.89	+48.88
Range	—	42.44pp	0.56pp	—

Cross-format comparison. Table 20 compares SFT and the best applicable regex baseline for each trace format. The SFT advantage increases with format complexity: `no_trace` (+3.62pp over majority baseline) < `full_trace` (+4.37pp) < `exception_only` (+6.22pp) ≪ VOTA (+23.86pp). The VOTA gap is largest because its structured multi-component format carries semantic content that regex cannot parse, while `exception_only`'s simpler format allows regex to capture most of the signal.

Q Cross-Model Zero-Shot Comparison

Table 21 compares zero-shot and SFT `exception_only` accuracy across four models. Zero-shot performance does not correlate with model size: the smallest model (Qwen-1.5B, 93.45%) outperforms all larger models, while the largest (CodeLlama-13B) falls below majority baseline. SFT compresses the 42.44pp zero-shot range to 0.56pp, eliminating architecture-dependent variance.